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PHI 101: Introduction to Philosophy and Logic

Arguments, fallacies and the questions that do not go away

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Philosophy | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

This pack teaches the mechanics of argument first, then the classical divisions of philosophy. It includes validity and soundness, common fallacies, the problem of knowledge, ethics and African philosophy, plus a template for writing a philosophy answer that argues rather than narrates.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Distinguish validity from soundness.
- Identify and name common informal fallacies.
- Explain the main branches of philosophy with an example question each.
- Write a short philosophical argument with an objection and a reply.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Arguments, validity and soundness

A good argument is structurally valid and materially true.

- Premises support a conclusion; the conclusion is what is claimed.
- Validity concerns form: if premises are true, the conclusion must be.
- Soundness requires validity plus true premises.
- Deductive arguments guarantee; inductive arguments support with probability.
- Counterexample is the standard tool for testing a claim.
- Define your terms before you argue about them.

Fallacies you will meet

Naming the fallacy is half the correction.

- Ad hominem: attacking the person instead of the argument.
- Straw man: refuting a distorted version of the opponent's view.
- False dilemma: presenting two options when more exist.
- Appeal to authority or to popularity as a substitute for evidence.
- Begging the question: assuming what you set out to prove.
- Hasty generalisation and post hoc reasoning.

> **Charity principle**
> Argue against the strongest version of the opposing view. Defeating a weak version proves nothing.

Branches and African philosophy

Each branch has characteristic questions.

- Metaphysics: what exists, and what is a person?
- Epistemology: what is knowledge, and when is belief justified?
- Ethics: what makes an action right?
- Logic: what follows from what?
- Aesthetics: what is beauty and what is art?
- African philosophy: ethnophilosophy debates, ubuntu and communitarian ethics, sage philosophy, and the critique of a single 'African' position.

Philosophy begins with a question you cannot answer quickly

Philosophy is not the accumulation of opinions about big topics. It is the practice of taking a question that ordinary life assumes and pressing it until the assumptions show. "Is it ever right to lie?" becomes philosophical when you ask what makes an action right at all, and discover that you cannot answer without a theory.

The discipline is divided into branches: epistemology (knowledge), metaphysics (existence, causation, mind), ethics (right action), political philosophy (justice and authority), aesthetics (art and beauty) and logic (correct inference). Each has its own questions and its own standards. Placing a question in a branch is the first move in any good answer.

African philosophy is a substantial part of this field, not a regional footnote. Debates about the existence and character of African philosophy - whether it lies in communal worldviews, in critical individual reflection, in proverbs and oral argument, or in professional academic practice - are methodological arguments with real consequences for what counts as philosophy.

The tools: argument, counter-example, distinction

An argument is a set of premises offered in support of a conclusion. Philosophy assesses the link between them. A valid argument cannot have true premises and a false conclusion; a sound argument is valid and has true premises. Most philosophical work is the construction and destruction of arguments, not the assertion of conclusions.

The counter-example is the philosopher's most efficient tool. To show that a definition fails, produce a case that fits the definition but not the concept, or the reverse. To test "knowledge is justified true belief", produce a case of accidentally justified true belief - and the definition is in trouble.

The distinction is the second tool. A great deal of confusion dissolves when two things wrongly treated as one are separated: causing harm and intending harm; believing and knowing; legal and moral obligation; explaining and justifying. Making a distinction is an argumentative move, not a neutral observation, and must be defended.

> **Charity before criticism**
> State your opponent's position in its strongest form, then answer it. Refuting a weak version proves nothing except that you can win against yourself.

Writing philosophy

A philosophy essay has a thesis, an argument for it, an objection, and a reply. It does not have a survey of everyone who ever wrote on the topic unless each is doing argumentative work. "Philosophers have long debated X" is a wasted sentence; "If Hume is right that reason alone cannot motivate action, then moral education must address desire, not only belief" is not.

Write in the present tense for positions ("Aristotle holds that...") and use examples. Abstract claims become testable when attached to a case: a trolley, a promise to a dying friend, a lie to protect someone. Philosophy without examples drifts into vocabulary.

Cite primary texts where possible and secondary sources for interpretation. Never attribute a position to a philosopher you have not read; if you know it only through a summary, say so or choose another target.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Testing a definition with counter-examples

A friend defines justice as "giving each person what they deserve". Assess it.

1. Clarify the definition: what does desert mean here - merit, need, contribution, legal entitlement?
2. Construct a counter-example: a person born with a disability who cannot contribute as others do, yet would receive little on a merit-based reading.
3. Ask whether the counter-example is decisive or whether the definition can be revised by distinguishing need from merit.
4. Consider a rival definition: justice as fair terms of cooperation.
5. Assess which definition handles more cases without collapsing into vagueness.
6. Conclude with a qualified position, not a verdict.

> **What to carry forward**
> Definitions are tested by cases, and revision is part of the argument.

2. Answering "is capital punishment justified?" in twenty minutes

A question that invites assertion. Build an argument instead.

1. Distinguish retributive, deterrent and restorative justifications.
2. State the strongest case for one and the empirical claim it requires.
3. Examine whether the evidence supports that empirical claim.
4. Present the strongest objection, including the problem of wrongful conviction.
5. Explain what would have to be true for your conclusion to hold.
6. Conclude with your position and its costs.

> **What to carry forward**
> Separate the moral argument from the empirical premise, and assess each.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Distinguish validity and soundness, and explain why philosophy cares about both.

15 marks

1. Define validity in terms of form.
2. Define soundness as validity plus true premises.
3. Give one valid-but-unsound example.
4. Explain the division of labour: logic checks inference; other inquiry checks premises.

Q2. Is there a distinctive African philosophy? Discuss.

20 marks

1. Set out the sceptical position: philosophy requires individual critical argument, not communal worldview.
2. Set out the reply: proverbs, oral debate and communal thought contain critical reasoning.
3. Discuss sage philosophy and the ethnophilosophy debate.
4. Assess what is at stake: who defines the discipline's boundaries.
5. Conclude with a defended position.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Treating the question as a matter of respect rather than of argument.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Argument. Premises offered in support of a conclusion.

Validity. The property that true premises cannot yield a false conclusion.

Soundness. Validity plus actually true premises.

Counter-example. A case that shows a definition or general claim to fail.

Premise. A proposition offered as support within an argument.

Epistemology. The branch of philosophy concerned with knowledge and justification.

Metaphysics. The branch concerned with what exists and its fundamental structure.

Ethics. The branch concerned with right action and the good life.

Ethnophilosophy. The reconstruction of a communal worldview as philosophy, criticised for lacking critical argument.

Sage philosophy. The critical thought of individual wise persons within a community.

Thought experiment. An imagined case used to test a principle or intuition.

Dilemma. A situation requiring a choice between options each with a cost.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Arguments

Form.

- Formalise five arguments from newspaper editorials.
- Test each for validity.
- Write one valid but unsound argument.

Week 2 - Branches

Placement.

- Sort ten questions by branch.
- Write the central question of each branch.
- Explain why placement changes method.

Week 3 - Cases

Thought experiments.

- Design a counter-example to a definition.
- Run one thought experiment in 300 words.
- Assess what intuition the case relies on.

Week 4 - Essay

Thesis, objection, reply.

- Draft a philosophy essay plan.
- Write the strongest objection.
- Complete a timed answer.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any introduction to philosophy with primary extracts rather than summaries only.
- A collection of African philosophy essays covering ethnophilosophy and sage philosophy.
- A short logic primer covering validity, soundness and common fallacies.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Can an argument be valid with false premises?

Answer: Yes. Validity concerns the form; soundness additionally requires true premises.

2. Name the fallacy of attacking a person rather than their argument.

Answer: Ad hominem.

3. What is begging the question?

Answer: An argument that assumes the truth of the conclusion it is supposed to establish.

4. Give one epistemological question.

Answer: What conditions must a true belief meet before it counts as knowledge?

5. What is the charity principle?

Answer: Interpreting an opponent's argument in its strongest reasonable form before criticising it.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write five arguments in premise-conclusion form.
- [ ] Test each for validity and soundness.
- [ ] Learn ten fallacies with an example.
- [ ] Read one short Platonic dialogue.
- [ ] Summarise one debate in African philosophy.
- [ ] Draft an essay with an objection and a reply.
- [ ] Peer-review for unstated assumptions.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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